

What does it mean to believe in fate? To believe in fate is to believe that there are now truths about all of the future actions that any of us will undertake.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to freedom that comes from fate.

So, for example, if fate is real then it is already true now that you will marry a certain person. Or, to pick a more grim example, there is already a truth about the exact moment you will die, and how.

So let's ask the question: is there such a thing as fate?

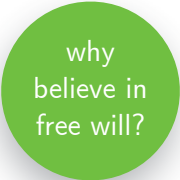
We might imagine that all of the facts about your life — past, present, and future — are written down in a dusty book in a library somewhere. Of course, there is no such book. But, if fate is real, then there could be. The truths are all there, whether or not they have been written down.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

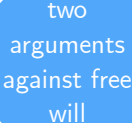
things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a



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responding to Edwards' argument. But

We'll shortly consider some ways of

first let's think about how Edwards'

for fatalsn.

argument might be related to an argument

Suppose that someone did not believe in

actions. Could they give an argument

similar to Edwards' argument?

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

there were truths about all our future

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

our future actions.

with reference to the being of truth about

God only shows up in premises (2) and



God knows that in the future I will

all of our activities.

then we have the choice about q.

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

1. We have no direct facts.

will perform various actions.

that if it is true that I will perform

perform a certain action (1,2)

2*In the past, there were truths about

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,



0 We have achieved what we

3 We have not the fact that

5* We have noticed that the fact

some action, then I will prefer that

acaioid.

(3, 4, 5)

The fatalist argument

in the first quarter of the book, one might find the sentence '[insert your name here]

entered South Dining Hall at 5:46 on 3/24/2019, and filled [his/her] plate with beef

written down in a dusty book in a library somewhere. So, for example, near the

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strongganoff.!

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Of course, there is no such book. But, if fate is real, then there could be. The truths are

have undertaken, and and suppose you had proof that the book was written well before

like the story about Osmo in the reading from Taylor for today.)

your birth. Would this cause you to doubt that your actions were free? (This is kind of

Suppose that you came across a book of this kind, which listed all the actions you

If so, then it seems that the very existence of fate should cause you to doubt your free

will. After all, the book would not have made you do anything. So whether or not the

book was really written seems irrelevant.

So let's ask the question: is there such a thing as fate?